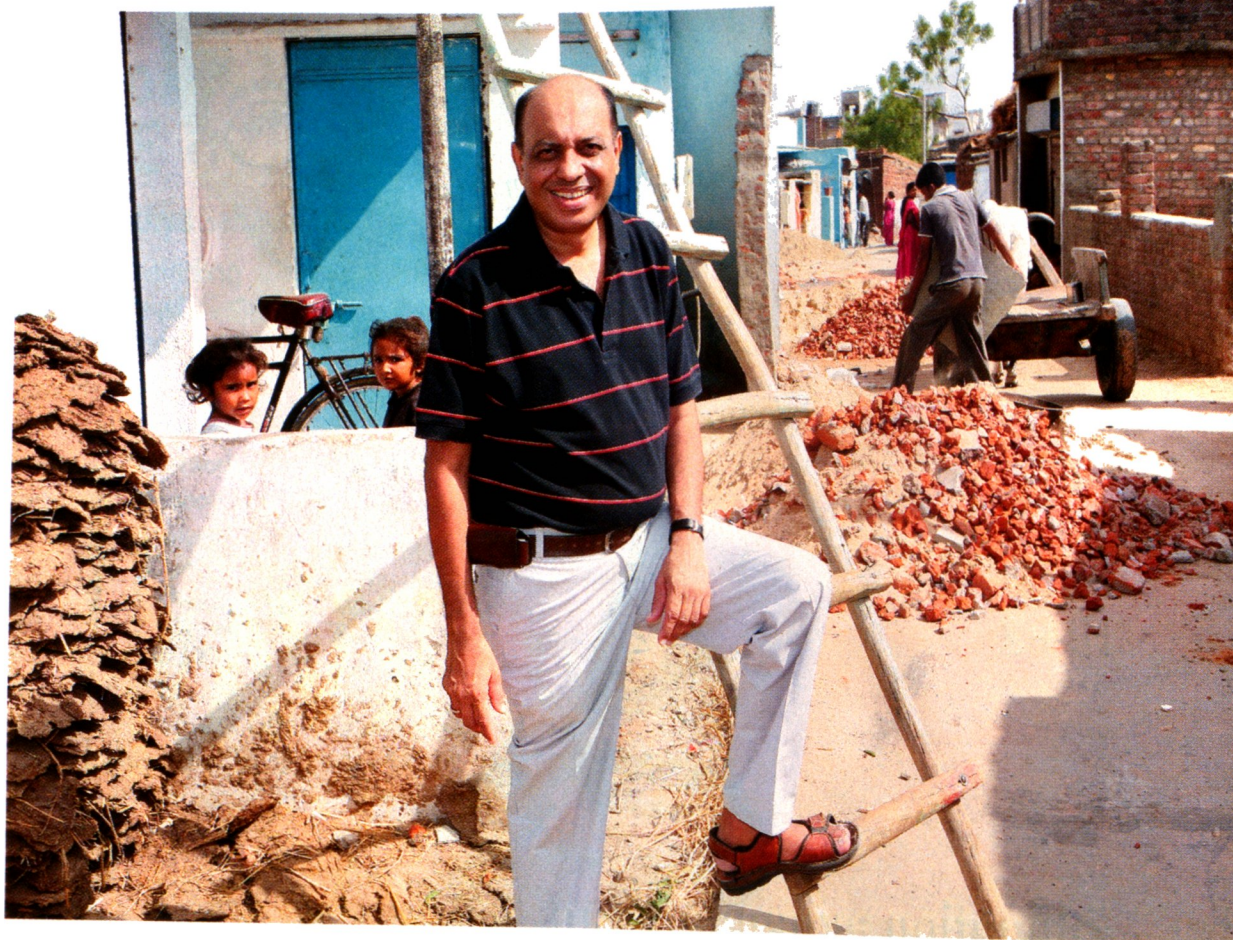




■ By Uday Mahurkar

city of DREAMS

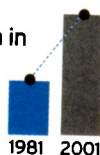
✱ **Rajendra Joshi, 50**

Project Uplift of
slum-dwellers via
his NGO, Saath

Can-do Icon Father
Ramiro Erviti, who taught
him the mantra to treat
slum-dwellers as equals,
not as objects of charity

6.2 crore

was the slum
population in India in
2001, more than
double from 2.8
crore in 1981



For this Tanzania-born NRI, slums are not irrelevant offshoots hindering Ahmedabad's urban renewal but necessary peripheries that are keeping its centre alive.

Rajendra Joshi has turned around the city's margins, transforming some into wanted lower middle-class destinations. In the last 15 years, his organisation, Saath, has helped

change the face of slums in the city. The biggest example of Joshi's vision is Gupta Nagar, a cluster of 1,500 households in Vasna area. "Most people living in slums want to upgrade their lives. They don't want freebies, despite what most people think. They just need initial support to be able to live well on their own. Saath wants to prove that they are willing to pay for services," says Joshi. He came to study in Gujarat and decided to stay on. He began his career as a

medical representative when a chance meeting with the late Roman Catholic priest Father Ramiro Erviti in Ahmedabad changed his life. Erviti, who worked in the slums, told him a sense of self respect had to be built in its dwellers.

Joshi realised this when he took up the Gupta Nagar slum project in 1993, working 10 hours a day. Many of its residents had invested in a personal sewerage line, an indication that they wanted to live better.